



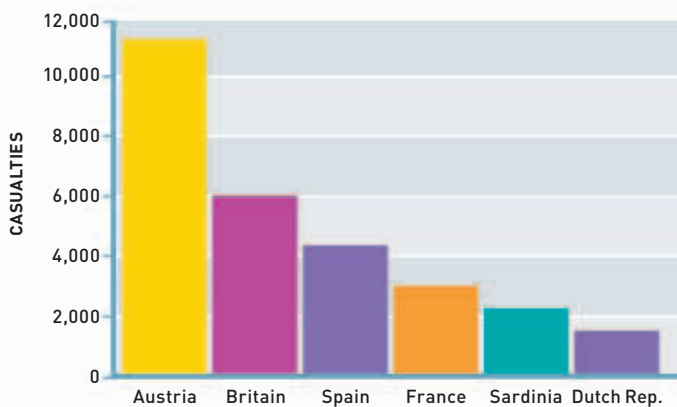
Admiral Sir George Byng's British fleet sail into the Straits of Messina prior to the Battle of Cape Passaro, in a painting by Richard Vale.

THE TREATY OF UTRECHT (see 1713) had ceded Sardinia and Sicily to Savoy, but the treaty was ignored by King Philip V of Spain (1683–1746), who sailed to capture the islands in 1717. Set against Philip was the **Triple Alliance** (see 1717) of Britain, France, and the Dutch Republic, which Austria joined on August 2, 1718, expanding it into the **Quadruple Alliance**. On July 21, Austria—under Holy Roman Emperor Charles VI (1685–1740)—had signed the **Treaty of Passarowitz**, ending the Austro-Turkish War (1716–18). This freed Charles's forces to turn their attention to Spain, and the **War of the Quadruple Alliance** was declared on December 17, 1718.

Previously, the Triple Alliance had set an ultimatum for the

War casualties

In the War of the Quadruple Alliance, 28,350 men were killed or wounded, including more than 2,000 from Sardinia, which was invaded by Spain.



withdrawal of Philip's invasion force. The British fleet, led by Sir George Byng, clashed with the Spanish invasion fleet—which had not been informed of the ultimatum—in the **Battle of Cape Passaro** on August 11, 1718. The larger Spanish warships were captured, while the smaller ships escaped. Later that year, an Austrian army landed at Messina, Sicily, to oust the Spanish garrison, but was defeated on October 15 in the first **Battle of Milazzo**.

In 1719 there were further attempts by the **Quadruple Alliance**, now joined by **Savoy**, to curb Spain. France invaded the Spanish **Basque Country** and then **Catalonia**, but disease forced both forces to withdraw. The Austrians attacked in **Sicily** and eventually the Spanish occupiers capitulated, their supplies having been blocked by the British navy. In another example of Spain's vulnerability from the sea, the British captured the port of **Vigo** in October.



This detail of a map by Willem Blau (c. 1650) shows the position of British-controlled Honduras, lying on the east coast of the Yucatán peninsula

THE BRITISH COLONY IN HONDURAS (now Belize), the only British possession in Central America before it gained full independence in 1981, was established on the eastern coast of the Yucatán peninsula by **British buccaneers**. By the turn of the 18th century the colony had begun to exploit the region's logwood (*Haematoxylum campechianum*), which yielded an important dye used for textiles and paper. In 1720, **slaves**—many from Jamaica and others directly from Africa—were first imported to this area of the so-called Mosquito Coast to expand logging operations on the Belize River.

The year 1720 saw the end of the War of the Quadruple Alliance (see 1718) with the signing of the **Treaty of the Hague**. Philip agreed to abandon his claims to Sicily and Sardinia, which came under the control of Austria and the Duchy of Savoy respectively, with the duke being titled king of Sardinia. In North America, the French returned **Pensacola** in Florida to King Philip V, along with places they had occupied in the north of Spain, receiving trade advantages in exchange. The treaty also confirmed **Texas** was a Spanish possession.

Meanwhile, the **Maratha**, a sub-ethnic group inhabiting the Maharashtra region of western India, began a major expansion of the empire that it had

Maratha expansion

The Maratha expanded their empire to the north, south, and east. Such was their reputation that they were able to raise taxes even beyond areas of their direct administration.

KEY

- Maratha Empire
- Maratha campaigns

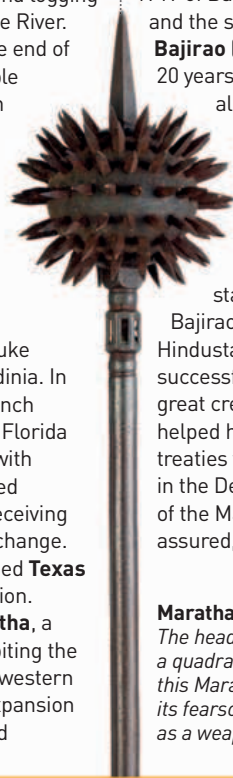


reestablished in 1674. The catalyst for the expansion, which began in 1720, was the death in 1719 of Balaji Vishwanath (b. 1680) and the succession of his son **Bajirao** (1700–40), who was only 20 years old at the time but already a charismatic and dynamic leader.

Recognizing the weakness of the grip that the **Mughal Empire**, based in Delhi, had on the states around him, Bajirao's army struck out into Hindustan. The campaign was successful and gained Bajirao great credit at home. This helped him negotiate peace treaties with Mughal authorities in the Deccan. With the security of the Maratha homeland assured, Bajirao began further

expansions in 1728, when he also moved his capital from Satara to **Pune**.

Far to the northeast, the **Zunghar Mongols** had taken possession of **Tibet** (see 1717). In 1720, a force of Qing and Tibetan warriors drove the Zunghars from Tibet. The Zunghars had killed the sixth Dalai Lama, claiming he was an impostor. The Qing force brought with it a replacement, Kelzang Gyatso, who was made the **seventh Dalai Lama**. Tibet became a tribute-paying protectorate of Qing China, and the Tibetan region of Kham was annexed to China's Sichuan province. However, disputes over who should govern under the Qing emperor resulted in **harsh suppressions** by the Chinese in the years that followed.



Maratha mace

The head of 118 spikes and a quadrangular top spike on this Maratha mace testify to its fearsome effectiveness as a weapon.

